rebuilt many times, it is the raid of Mahmud Ghazni that is still remembered most vividly.

The temple that stands on the site today was built in the early 1950s. Its symbolic importance can be gauged from the fact that its reconstruction was one of the first major projects initiated by the Indian Republic. Standing right on the seashore, the temple is a wonderful place to watch the sun set even as the sound of the evening ‘arati’ drifts across from the inner sanctum. Yet, something of the horror of that medieval massacre seems to linger in the air. Barely half a kilometre away is the spot where the Pandav warrior Arjun is said to have conducted the last rites of Krishna. Three rivers meet the sea here—one of them named after the Saraswati.

The Turkish raids were no doubt inspired partly by religious zeal and partly by the lure of plunder. However, it is often forgotten that one of their most important motivations was the capture of slaves. [12] Over the next few centuries, hundreds of thousands of Indian slaves—particularly from West Punjab and Sindh—would be marched into Afghanistan and then sold in the bazaars of Central Asia and the Middle East. Unused to the extreme cold of the Afghan mountains, they died in such large number that the range would come to be known as the Hindukush meaning ‘Killer of Hindus’.

Despite the shock of Mahmud Ghazni’s raids, however, there was no equivalent to the Mauryan or Gupta responses to foreign invasion. The last great Hindu empire of North India—that of the Gujara–Pratiharas—was in steep decline and the creative heart of Indic civilization had shifted south of the Vindhyas. The most powerful Indian kingdom of that time, the Cholas, ruled in the far south and would not have been concerned with the gathering clouds in the North West. Meanwhile, freed from the political and cultural domination of the Gangetic plains, Central India experienced a cultural and economic boom. This was the age of the remarkable Raja Bhoj, the warrior-scholar who ruled much of Central India and of the Chandelas of Bundelkhand who built the temples of Khajuraho.

Academic historians tend to ignore Raja Bhoj but the oral tradition of Central India is full of stories and ballads about him. It is difficult to ascertain the veracity of all these tales but one cannot deny the geographical